

Where English began

ENGLISH, POWER, ACCESS



English has no birthday

Germanic settlers crossed the sea.

Their dialects shaped Old English.

Settlement began in the 400s.

A process, over generations.

Old English was Germanic

WEST GERMANIC

Old Frisian. Old Saxon.

These languages shared ancestry.

Some words stayed

OLD ENGLISH

hand

word

TODAY

hand

word

Writing came later

Speech preceded surviving manuscripts.

Cædmon's Hymn survives in copies.

One copy dates to 800–830.

Found in Rome in 2026.

No single dialect

WEST SAXON

KENTISH ANGLIAN

Surviving texts favor West Saxon.

Scribes varied their spelling.

French entered after conquest

1066

Normans conquered England.

French words entered English.

Change took time.

Sources and limits

Texas Linguistics Research Center

lrc.la.utexas.edu/eieol/engol/0

Trinity College Dublin

tcd.ie/news_events/articles/2026/caedmons-hymn-discovery/

Texts show survivors, not beginnings.

NEXT: Ancient Britain before English